UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

PART I: JOB READINESS

TOPIC 1: MOTIVATION AND INITIATIVE

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand what it means to take initiative
- Understand the importance of taking initiative at work
- Understand how motivation is connected to taking initiative

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Complete a handout on self-motivation as a self-reflection exercise
- Develop a list of things they could do at different jobs to demonstrate initiative

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Roll the Dice

Objective: Students will think about the importance of working hard and smart.
Time: 10 minutes
Materials: Five dice, small prize

Ask for a volunteer to come to the front of the room. Hold out the dice, but hand just one to the volunteer. Avoid encouraging them to take other dice. Tell the volunteer to throw six 'sixes' in thirty seconds to win a small prize. (If you have colored dice, let them know they need to get 12 'greens' to win the prize.) Keep the other dice in your hand throughout the exercise. Let them know when they have twenty seconds left and count down the last ten seconds out loud. (If there is time, you could ask for another volunteer and give them a chance to try.)

Learning points:

- The chance of getting the six 'sixes' increases with the number of throws. Did the person start throwing faster in the last ten seconds? (If more than one person tried, did the second person roll faster throughout the activity? Why do you think this might be?) Too often in life we don't 'throw quickly' until there is a crisis or a deadline. Why wait until the week before you have to go to court to do your community service hours or get a letter of support? Why wait until the night before a test to study? Why wait until June to try to get a summer job? Why wait until the day of a job interview to try to find something to wear?
- The thrower could have asked for more dice. Explain that you would have given the volunteer more dice if she/he had asked. The more dice being thrown, the greater the chance of getting the 'sixes'. How often do we make things more difficult because we don't ask for help or additional resources? What is the chance of getting what you want/need if you ask for it? What is the chance if you don't ask?
- Someone with average skills can easily outperform a more skillful employee if he/she targets their effort more effectively and uses their time more efficiently. Success is not always about skills — determination, motivation, work ethic, initiative and attitude are key components to success.

Adapted from http://www.businessballs.com/freeteambuildingactivities.htm#team-building-games-exercises-activities retrieved April 12 2010

Large Group Discussion

Objectives:
- Students will understand the importance of taking initiative.
- Students will understand how motivation is connected to taking initiative.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"Self-Motivation,"** pens/pencils

Read the following quote to students: "A recent poll of executives asked, 'What do you feel is the single best way for employees to earn a promotion and/or raise?' Topping the list for 82% of the respondents was, 'Ask for more work and responsibility.' Employees who take initiative greatly enhance their chances for recognition, learning, advancement, pay raises, and bonuses — and have a more meaningful and exciting time at work." ~ *Bob Nelson*
From **http://www.inc.com/articles/1999/09/16417.html#** retrieved April 15, 2010

Ask students what they think about what you just read? Ask students what taking initiative means? The definition we will focus on for today's discussion is: without prompting or direction from others: on one's own (from **www.thefreedictionary.com**) Why is it important to be able to do things on your own at work?

Hand out **"Self-Motivation"** and ask students to take a few minutes to answer the questions. Discuss the questions and answers.

Small Group Exercise

Objectives:
- Complete a handout on self-motivation as a self-reflection exercise.
- Develop a list of things they could do at different jobs to demonstrate initiative.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handouts: **"Exercise: Taking Initiative"** and **"Taking Initiative At Work,"** pens/pencils

Divide students into four small groups. Hand out **"Exercise: Taking Initiative"** and instruct the small groups to discuss the scenario and the questions. Have each group take the lead on one of the questions for the larger group discussion.

Divide the students into three small groups. Hand out **"Taking Initiative at Work"** and instruct each group to work on three jobs. Have the groups present their ideas to the larger group and see if people from other groups have additional ideas to share.

Remind students that taking initiative is important, but that they must also remember that some ideas should be discussed with a supervisor before employees start working on them (as discussed in the example with Margaret).

Self-Motivation

Taking the Initiative:

1. **Why is self-motivation important?**

2. **What motivates you?**

3. **Who is responsible for motivating you in the workplace? Your supervisor? Your peers? Yourself? Why?**

4. **What happens if you don't take responsibility for motivating yourself?**

5. **Can you think of any situation in which you would take on extra work, even if you were not getting compensated for it? Why or why not?**

Exercise: Taking Initiative

Scenario: Read the following scenario. Discuss it in your small group.

Margaret just got hired as a clerk in a medical laboratory. She is an extremely hard worker and is eager to prove herself to her new employer. After only a few weeks on the job, she comes up with what she thinks is a better and more efficient way to process customer accounts. To impress her boss, she comes in early one morning to implement her plan. Margaret's boss arrives at work and is upset to find the office in a mess as she attempts to put her plan into action.

Discussion Questions:

1. Do you think that what Margaret did was wrong? Why or why not?
2. What could she have done differently?
3. How do you know your limitations at work?
4. How does this scenario demonstrate the importance of knowing the difference between taking the initiative and knowing your limitations?

Taking Initiative at Work

When you are at work, there are always extra little things that can be done. Try to think of at least three things you could do if things are slow at work in the following jobs/place of employment:

1. Fast food restaurant

2. Summer camp

3. Office

4. Retail store

5. Ice cream parlor

6. Coffee shop

7. Book store

8. Grocery store

9. Auto-mechanic shop